Finding the Best Walk in Portland

Sep 28, 2026 · @Torri Porter

In a city built for biking, I used data to find the best path for walking in Portland.

Why walking

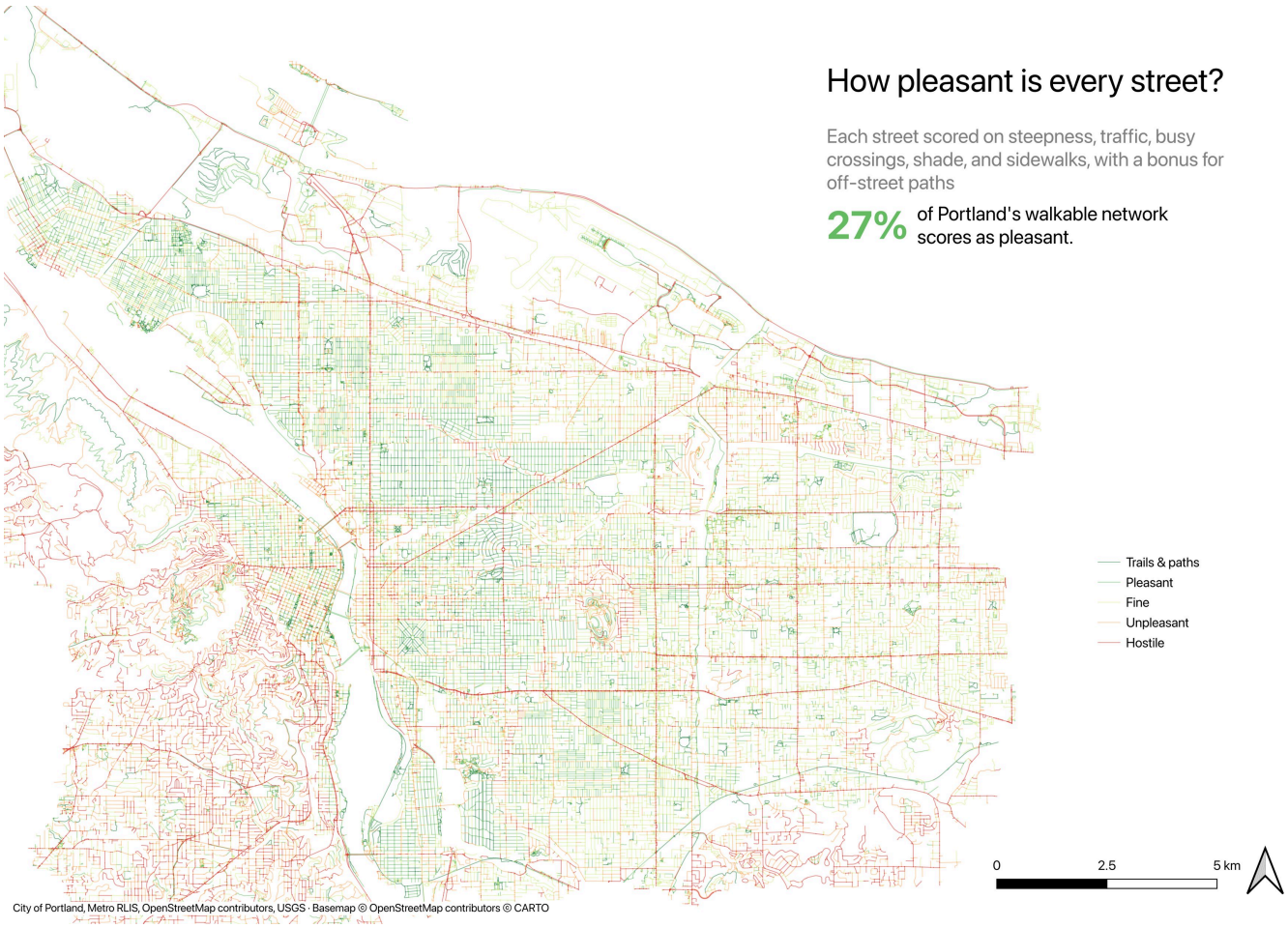
In my 20s I was lucky enough to live in Vancouver, BC. To help deal with the stress of school exams, I picked up the hobby of taking long walks across town. One of my favorite paths was the Arbutus Greenway, a 9 km purpose-built pathway that crosses a variety of neighborhoods. Its single best trait: because it was built on an old railway, the path is largely uninterrupted by road crossings.

When I moved to Portland in 2023, I looked for a path that filled that same desire to walk for hours uninterrupted. There are a number of great short loops, but no long paths that take you across town. Portland can't build an uninterrupted walking path through the city, so I asked myself a question: where is the best crosstown walking path in Portland?

What makes a good walk

First I needed a foundation: what makes a walking path "pleasant"? I landed on the factors that decide how far someone is willing to walk down a street: steepness, traffic, speed limits, busy crossings, shade, sidewalk quality, and whether the path runs off the main roads.

Using these, I scored every street and path in Portland. In Map 1, greener streets are more pleasant for walking. **27% of Portland's walkable network scores as pleasant.**

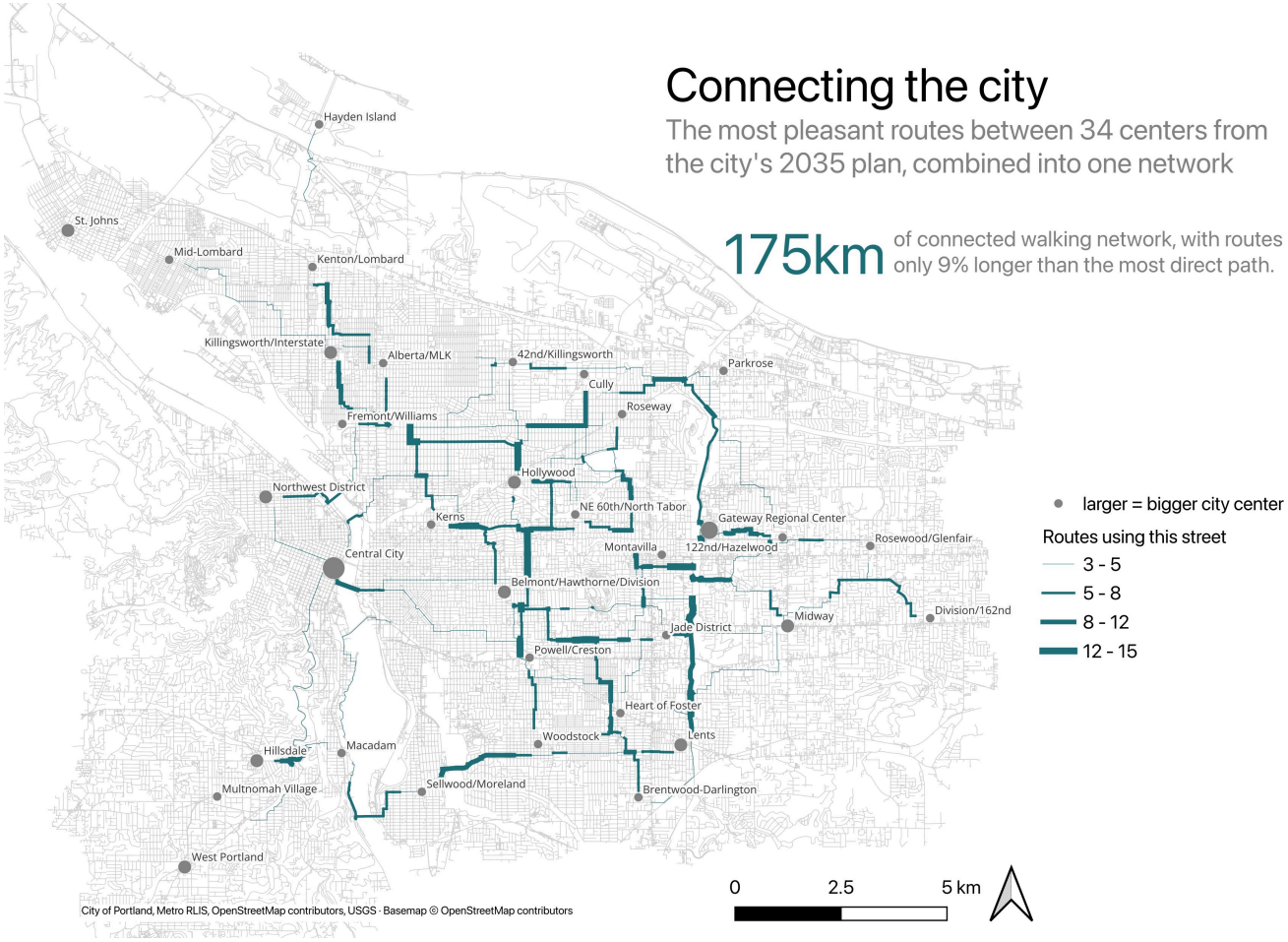


Connecting the city

Beyond the quality of the street itself, a good walking path has to actually take you somewhere. The Arbutus Greenway runs from False Creek, just outside downtown, to the Fraser River and a train station, both bustling places. On the way you pass the small shops and community gardens of Kerrisdale and Marpole.

Portland's 2035 Comprehensive Plan names 34 "centers" across town. I used these centers as anchors for where walking paths should start and stop, the idea being that a good walking path connects neighborhood centers together.

Map 2 shows the most pleasant paths connecting all of the city's centers; thicker lines mean more paths use that street. **175 km of pleasant streets connect Portland's centers,** with routes only 9% longer than the most direct path.

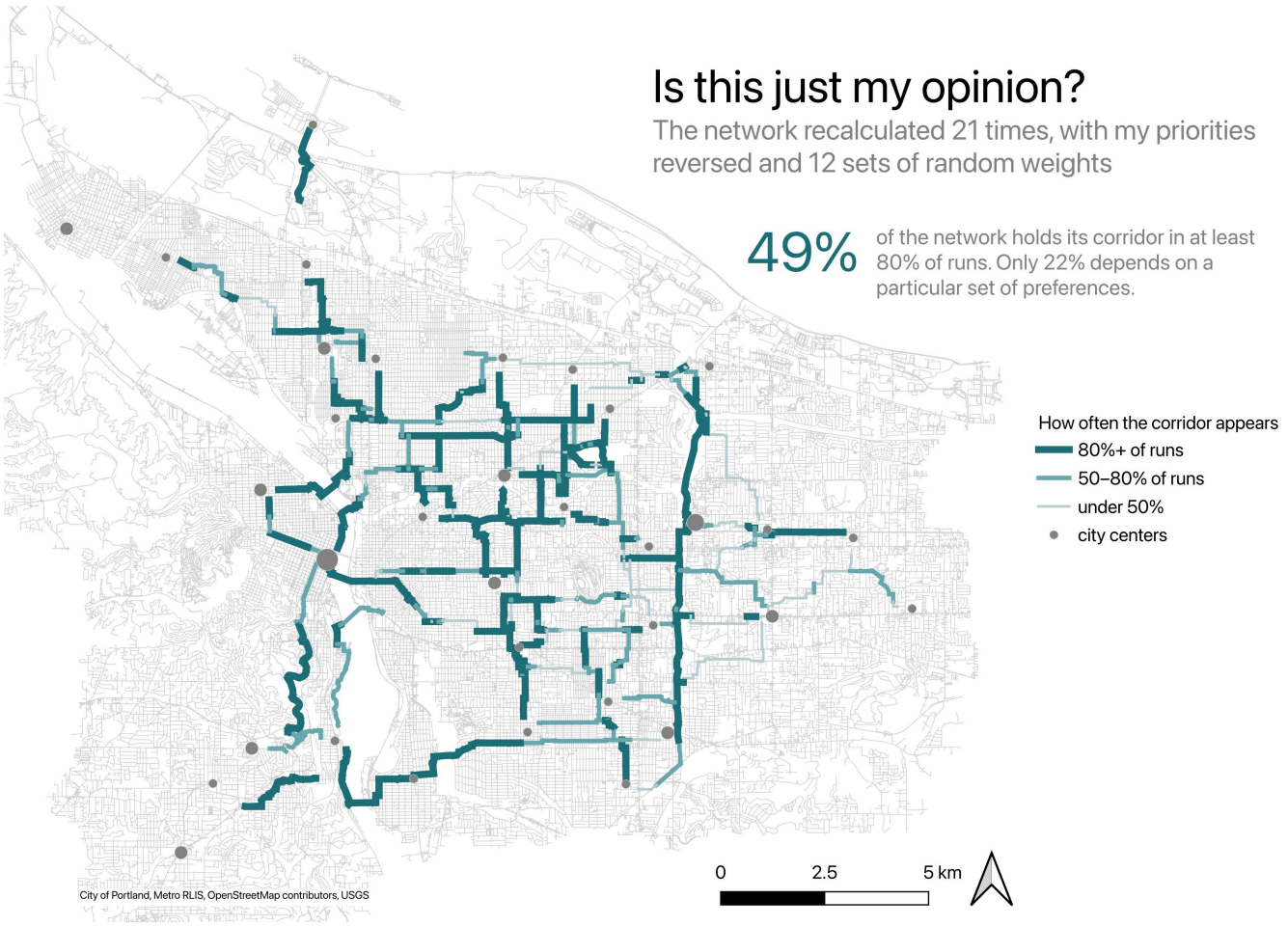


Just my opinion?

At this point I had to ask myself: how much of this is just my opinion? The paths so far rest entirely on the factors I chose and the weight I gave each one. So I reran the analysis 21 times, each with different weights, including my priorities reversed and 12 sets of random weights.

Map 3 shows the result. **Nearly half of the network (49%) holds its corridor in at least 80% of runs, and only 22% depends on a particular set of preferences.** The corridors themselves rarely changed; the exact streets they followed sometimes did.

E Burnside, NE Broadway, and the Hawthorne Bridge are robust not because they're pleasant, but because they're chokepoints that every route has to use. That makes them strong candidates for pedestrian improvements.



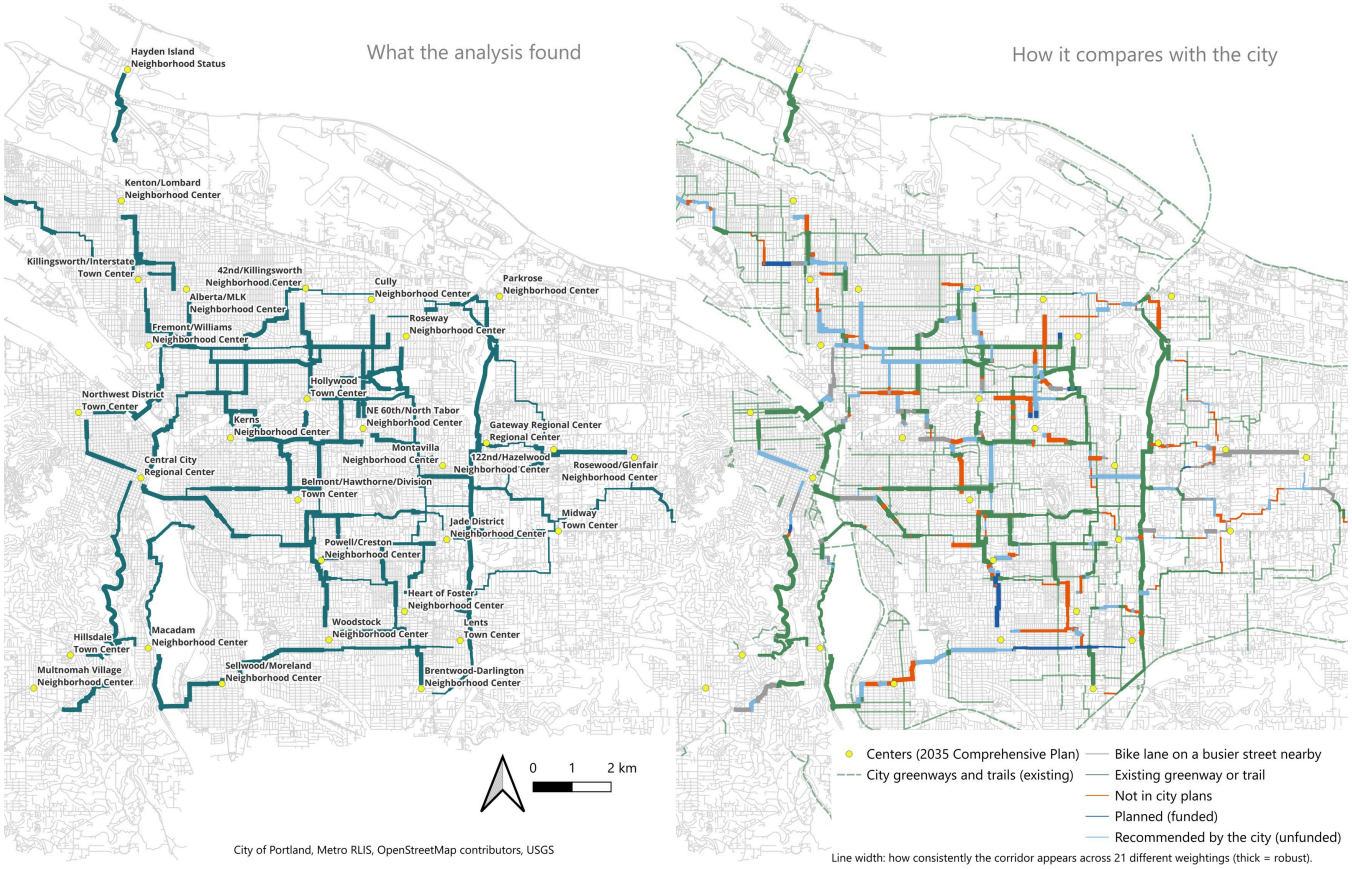
Does the city agree?

Up to this point I hadn't used any City of Portland greenway data: the goal was to find the best paths based only on my own factors. Then I compared the results with the city's plans. Map 4 shows how they line up.

Share of the network	What the city has there
49%	Existing greenways and trails
4%	Planned and funded
21%	Recommended by the city, but unfunded
8%	Only a bike lane on a busier street nearby
18%	Not in city plans

74% of the network is already built, funded, or recommended as a greenway. The 21% that both the analysis and the city recommend, but that isn't funded yet, is a ready-made priority list. The 18% not in city plans is mostly short connections between existing greenways.

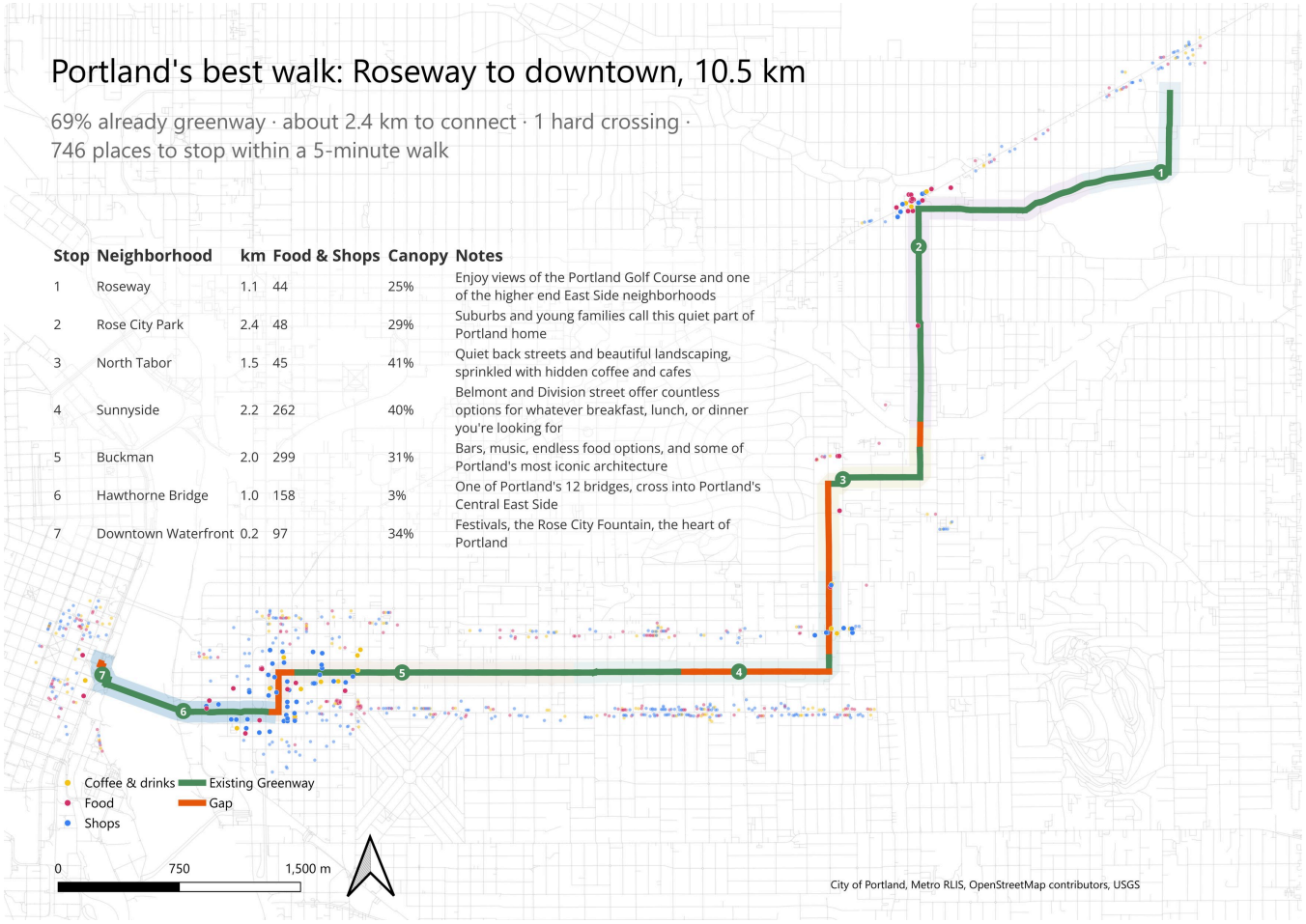
Portland's connector network: 175 km linking 34 centers.



The very best walk: Roseway to Downtown Waterfront

Now back to my original question: what is the very best walking path in Portland? To answer it, I added one more layer to the analysis. Beyond the path itself, what made the Arbutus so great was the number of neighborhoods it passes through and the shops and points of interest along the way.

Map 5 shows the single best walking path by how pleasant it is, how many neighborhoods it passes through, and how much there is to stop for nearby: **10.5 km from Roseway to the Downtown Waterfront, through seven neighborhoods, and already 69% greenway.**



Measured the same way, it matches the Arbutus Greenway remarkably closely:

Measure	Roseway to downtown	Arbutus Greenway
Length	10.5 km	9 km
Neighborhoods	7	6
Shops and food per km	71	73
Transit stops per km	11	12
Average grade	2%	Gentle former rail grade
Major-road crossings per km	0.86	0.44
Benches per km	0	4.3
Already a greenway	69%	100%

The real differences are the crossings, which the Arbutus avoids thanks to its railway history, and the built-in amenities like benches.

The real test was walking it. After first riding the route by bike, I walked the whole path, and it really is an incredibly pleasant walk. Along the way we passed street art, beautifully painted homes and manicured landscapes, and families out for walks and bike rides. Salmon Street was full of yard sales and block parties. We stopped for coffee, and later for burgers, and it made for a great day on foot.

The data backs up what we saw. The quiet path runs between busy main streets: 109 places to stop are right on the path, and another 637 are a short detour away. The only hard crossing was Cesar Chavez Boulevard, and the least pleasant stretches, 45th Avenue and 6th Avenue, turned out to be exactly the gaps the analysis flagged.

What it would take: about 2.4 km of new greenway connections, a safer crossing at Salmon Street and Cesar Chavez, and Arbutus-style amenities such as benches, water fountains, and gardens.

Key takeaways

Portland's best walk already mostly exists: 69% of the Roseway-to-downtown route is existing greenway, and about 2.4 km of new connections plus a handful of fixes would make it a complete walkway.

Where	Length	Today
NE and SE 45th Avenue	1.1 km	Not a greenway; one of the least pleasant stretches on the walk
SE Salmon Street, west of 45th Avenue	0.9 km	Gap before the existing Salmon greenway begins
SE Salmon Street at Cesar Chavez Boulevard	Crossing	The route's only hard crossing
SE 6th Avenue	0.2 km	Short gap; the other least pleasant stretch
NE 53rd Avenue	0.2 km	A short gap inside the existing greenway

Where	Length	Today
Central Eastside bridge approach (Grand/MLK, 11th/12th, Hawthorne/Madison)	Crossings	Busy one-way street pairs at the bridgehead
Hawthorne Bridge	1.0 km	Existing paths, but only 3% tree canopy
The whole route	10.5 km	No benches mapped within 50 m of the path

Sources

- **City of Portland** (PortlandMaps open data): speed limits, Transportation System Plan classes, sidewalks, bikeways, neighborhoods, and the 2035 Comprehensive Plan centers
- **Metro RLIS:** Canopy 2019
- **OpenStreetMap contributors:** street and path network, shops, transit stops, and points of interest
- **USGS 3DEP:** elevation
- **City of Vancouver:** Arbutus Greenway facts

Every step of the analysis is reproducible from the project repository.